BELUR AND HALEBIDU: SACRED ENSEMBLES OF THE HOYSALAS (?????? - ???????)

HOYSALA DYNASTY AND UNESCO RECOGNITION

The Hoysala Empire ruled over Karnataka from the 10th to 14th centuries CE, establishing their principal capitals at Belur (Velapuri) and Halebidu (Dorasamudra) in Hassan district. In September 2023, the 'Sacred Ensembles of the Hoysalas' were inscribed as a UNESCO World Heritage Site in recognition of their unsurpassed sculptural virtuosity, intricate micro-carvings, and unique stellate temple architecture.

ARCHITECTURAL CHARACTERISTICS

Hoysala temples are constructed from soft chloritic schist (soapstone) that hardens upon atmospheric exposure, permitting jewel-like ornamental detail. Temples stand on elevated star-shaped platforms (jagati) providing an open circumambulatory path (pradakshinapatha) around the perimeter.

BELUR CHENNAKESHAVA TEMPLE COMPLEX

COMMISSIONING AND DEDICATION

The Chennakeshava Temple at Belur was commissioned in 1117 CE by King Vishnuvardhana (formerly Bittideva) to celebrate his military triumph over the Chola Viceroy of Talakadu at the historic Battle of Talakadu and his conversion from Jainism to Vaishnavism under the guidance of saint Ramanujacharya.

MADANIKAS (BRACKET FIGURES)

The exterior pillars feature 42 celebrated bracket figures (Madanikas or Salabhanjikas) representing feminine beauty, music, and dance. The most famous is 'Darpana Sundari' (the beauty admiring herself in a mirror), alongside the Huntress, the Drummer, and the Lady with a Parrot. The inner navaranga hall contains polished lathed pillars of black soapstone, notably the Mohini pillar and the intricately carved Narasimha pillar.

HALEBIDU HOYSALESWARA TEMPLE

TWIN TEMPLE ARCHITECTURE

Commissioned around 1121 CE by King Vishnuvardhana and wealthy merchant Ketamalla, the Hoysaleswara Temple is a monumental twin-shrine (dvikuta) complex dedicated to Hoysaleswara and Shantaleswara (named after Queen Shantala Devi). Designed by master architect Kedaroja.

WALL FRIEZES AND NARRATIVE RELIEFS

The exterior base features eight continuous horizontal tiers of relief friezes: the lowest layer with 1,248 charging war elephants, followed by lions, floral scrolls, cavalry horses, narrative friezes, makaras (mythical sea creatures), and hamsas (sacred swans). The upper walls display over 240 colossal sculptures of Hindu deities, including Lord Shiva as Gajasurasamhara dancing on the slain elephant demon, Vishnu, Brahma, Saraswati, and Ravana lifting Mount Kailash.